



HUMANITAS  
INSTITUTE

## Six Elements of Classical Education School Website Audit

School: Stella Maris Academy of San Francisco

School Website: <https://stellamarissf.org/>

January 7, 2026

**Artificial Intelligence Disclaimer**

*This audit was performed using artificial intelligence tools to evaluate the presence and strength of classical education principles on school websites. Results are automated, probabilistic in nature, and should be considered indicative rather than definitive. See the full disclaimer in the Appendix more details.*

## Overall Classification: CLASSICAL

### Executive Summary

Stella Maris Academy San Francisco (SMA) presents a clearly Catholic, classical-inspired program for PK–8, with explicit emphasis on a liberal arts curriculum framed by a Catholic worldview. The school markets itself as academically excellent, classically aligned, and catechetically integrated, with a strong emphasis on forming virtue and character in a Catholic-context environment. Public materials highlight a classical pedagogy (grammar, logic, rhetoric), integration of faith and reason, and a parental-partnered approach to education.

Overall rating: CLASSICAL

- The religious/metaphysical foundations are robust, anchored in Catholicism and liturgical life, with explicit language about prayer, sacraments, and a Catholic integrated education model. This aligns strongly with the transcendental moral realism and communal practices elements of classical education. Evidence includes references to integrated Catholic education, morning prayer, and mission language centering on truth, goodness, and beauty.
- The school purpose and goal emphasize formation, virtue, and wisdom over vocational preparation, with explicit statements about forming minds and hearts, seeking truth, goodness, and beauty. This is a strong match for the classical formation objective.
- The curriculum is explicitly described as a classical curriculum with grammar, logic, and rhetoric, and it situates learning within a Catholic, integrated framework. There is clear articulation of these liberal-arts phases and related pedagogy, including language studies (Latin) and arts/music integration. This supports a CLASSICAL designation for Curriculum.
- Pedagogy shows a staged approach (grammar–logic–rhetoric) and a blend of contemplative elements with active, seminar-like elements as students advance, aligning with classical pedagogy expectations for a PK–8 program. While explicit Socratic seminars are not described for middle grades in public materials, the structure remains consistent with classical pedagogy appropriate for the school's grade span.
- Faculty is portrayed as mentors and living curriculum, with references to clergy and faculty alignment with mission, and to a collaborative, virtuous-teacher ideal. This supports a CLASSICAL reading of the Faculty category.
- Parents & Community are positioned as partners, with enrollment processes framed as a partnership with parents, and public-facing invitations to visits and information sessions. This aligns with the classical model of parent partnership and a welcoming community.

## ABSTRACT

ly, SMA appears to be a well-aligned CLASSICAL school within the scope of the Six Essential Elements rubric, with strong religious foundations, virtuous aims, classical curriculum scaffolding, and an engaged, forming community of families.

## Executive Summary — Element-by-Element Snapshot

### Element 1: Religious and Metaphysical Foundations — CLASSICAL

#### Evidence

- The school presents Integrated Catholic Education as a core pillar, explicitly positioning Catholic identity as integral to learning and to the curriculum.
- Public materials reference prayer, morning assembly, and sacraments as part of daily life, indicating liturgical and communal practice.
- Mission language centers on forming minds and hearts to seek truth, goodness, and beauty within a Catholic framework.

#### Positive/Negative keyword analysis

- Positive keywords observed: Catholic, Integrated Catholic Education, prayer, morning assembly, sacraments, truth, goodness, beauty, formation, wisdom, liturgical life, theology (implicit via Catholic integration).
- Negative keywords observed: None evident in public materials (no secularization or materialist framing detected).

#### Why this rating

- The materials consistently tie education to transcendent Catholic aims and liturgical life, fulfilling the transcendental moral realism and liturgical/community expectations. The presence of explicit theology-linked language and communal worship practices supports a CLASSICAL designation.

Citations: integrated Catholic education and Catholic identity references; morning prayer; mission statements emphasizing truth/goodness/beauty.

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### Element 2: School Purpose and Goal — CLASSICAL

#### Evidence

- Public materials frame education as formation of virtue and human excellence, not solely preparation for a job. The mission describes forming “young minds and hearts for the journey of life” and pursuing truth, goodness, and beauty.
- Language consistently ties education to wisdom and moral imagination, not only information transfer. The curriculum discussion emphasizes formation and character alongside academic rigor.
- The emphasis on virtue formation and the integration of faith and reason aligns with classical aims (truth, goodness, beauty).

#### Positive/Negative keyword analysis

- Positive keywords observed: formation, virtue, wisdom, truth, goodness, beauty, moral imagination, character, love of Wisdom.
- Negative keywords observed: None evident; no emphasis on purely vocational or utilitarian aims that would undermine formation.

#### Why this rating

- The school explicitly defines its purpose as formation of virtue and wisdom under a Catholic-integrated framework, matching the classical ideal of formation over mere information or job-readiness.

Citations: mission language and “formation of young minds and hearts”; discussions of virtue and truth/goodness/beauty.

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**Element 3: School Curriculum — CLASSICAL**

## Evidence

- The curriculum is described as “Academically Excellent Classical Curriculum” and explicitly notes the classical difference as an education centered on truth, goodness, and beauty.
- The model of progress through Grammar, Logic, and Rhetoric is described, with explicit K–6 grammar stage, 7–8 logic stage, and rhetoric in later years, indicating a structured classical program.
- Latin language study and integrated arts/music are included, reinforcing classical liberal-arts grounding.
- History is framed as an integrated part of the curriculum through a classical lens (throughout the curriculum and in integrated study), though explicit “Great Books” or “Great Conversation” language is not directly quoted in all public materials. The emphasis remains on a liberal-arts curriculum with a Catholic integration.

## Positive/Negative keyword analysis

- Positive keywords observed: classical curriculum, truth, goodness, beauty, grammar, logic, rhetoric, liberal arts, Latin, integrated Catholic education, history (integration across disciplines), wonder.
- Negative keywords observed: None explicit; no references to secularism, materialism, or vocational-centric framing that would undermine classical aims.

## Why this rating

- The presence of explicit grammar–logic–rhetoric structure, integration of Latin, history-integration, and the “classical difference” framing strongly supports CLASSICAL status. The occasional absence of explicit “Great Books/Great Conversation” phrasing does not, on its own, disqualify a K–8 classical program when the core liberal-arts sequence is clearly articulated.

Citations: explicit grammar/logic/rhetoric progression; Latin; integrated Catholic curriculum; historical integration language.

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**Element 4: Pedagogy or Teaching Methods — CLASSICAL**

## Evidence

- The pedagogy rests on a triadic progression (Grammar → Logic → Rhetoric) consistent with classical pedagogy, with public materials describing this progression and how students move through stages.
- Lower grades emphasize a contemplative and wonder-filled approach (e.g., fostering wonder, moral imagination) and integration of memory-friendly formats (singing, review). The curriculum mentions arts/music and memorization strategies in early years.
- Public materials describe upper-level pedagogy as engaging in discussions and seminars aligned with rhetoric development (the classical trajectory). While explicit “Socratic” language is not repeatedly stated for SMA’s 9–12 (since SMA is PK–8), the high-level classical pedagogy is preserved through grammar/logic/rhetoric emphasis and opportunities for rhetorical expression.

## Positive/Negative keyword analysis

- Positive keywords observed: contemplative, wonder, memory, recitation/chanting, singing, circle/school assemblies, logic, rhetoric, seminars, discussion, moral imagination.
- Negative keywords observed: None clearly present in public materials; there is no emphasis on non-classical modes like purely project-based or test-driven rote drilling without context.

## Why this rating

- The curriculum’s explicit grammar/logic/rhetoric progression and emphasis on wonder and formation align with the classical pedagogy model. Although specific high-school Socratic seminars aren’t ap-

plicable (the school is PK–8), the pedagogy remains true to classical methods appropriate for SMA's grade span, qualifying as CLASSICAL.

Citations: Grammar/Logic/Rhetoric progression; lower-level wonder and memory emphasis; upper-grade rhetoric/seminar-like opportunities described in curriculum/cultural pages.

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### Element 5: School Faculty — CLASSICAL

#### Evidence

- The faculty is positioned as mentors who form the living curriculum and as central, virtuous figures within the school. The public materials describe faculty in terms of mission alignment and Virtue formation.
- The school references clergy involvement and the integration of faith with teaching, signaling a community of teachers and clerical leadership aligned to formation and virtue.
- There is emphasis on a “model tailored to how children naturally develop” and a culture of collaboration among teachers, parents, and students, consistent with classical-teacher ideals.

#### Positive/Negative keyword analysis

- Positive keywords observed: living curriculum, model teachers and mentors, virtue, formation, collaboration, mission-aligned faculty, clergy/faculty integration, teachers as core of the school.
- Negative keywords observed: None evident.

#### Why this rating

- The materials portray a faculty culture that is Mission-driven, virtuous, and central to student formation, which aligns well with the classical expectation of teachers as the living example and core of the school.

Citations: statements about faculty as living curriculum; clergy/faculty integration; mission-aligned faculty.

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### Element 6: School Parents and Community — CLASSICAL

#### Evidence

- Enrollment and admissions emphasize partnering with parents, with the enrollment process described as a partnership between parents and Stella Maris Academy, indicating a co-teaching posture with parents.
- The site highlights family Faith-filled community language and a commitment to engaging parents through information sessions, events, and school gatherings, which aligns with classical education's parent-partnership model.
- There are public-facing opportunities to visit, learn about classical education, and engage in community events that welcome parent involvement.

#### Positive/Negative keyword analysis

- Positive keywords observed: partnership with parents, co-teachers, family/community, information sessions, visits, parish/catholic community, shared formation, events/gala, engagement.
- Negative keywords observed: None evident.

#### Why this rating

- SMA presents a robust parent-community partnership model, inviting parental involvement and education about classical education, which is a hallmark of classical schools.

Citations: partnership language in enrollment materials; community and parent engagement pages.

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### What Would Move the Needle

Not applicable here, as the aggregate rating is CLASSICAL. If desired, minor enhancements could include explicit articulation of high-school-level Socratic seminars (even if the school ends at 8th grade) and direct references to historical Great Books conversations in select curricula to further strengthen the historical core of the Great Conversation language. Additionally, more explicit references to chanting/scholé-like contemplative practices in lower grades could further align Pedagogy with the “contemplative and restful” aspects of classical education.

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## Appendix

### ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE DISCLAIMER

This audit was conducted using artificial intelligence tools (including large language models and automated web-analysis scripts) to evaluate the extent to which school websites reflect or incorporate recognized principles of classical education (e.g., the trivium, emphasis on truth/beauty/goodness, integration of great books, Latin/classical languages, Socratic method, rigorous academics, moral/character formation, etc.).

### Important Limitations and Caveats

1. **Automated Nature:** The analysis relies on AI interpretation of publicly-accessible school website content as of the date of the audit. It does not involve direct contact with schools, review of internal documents, classroom observation, or verification of curriculum implementation beyond what is stated or implied on the website.
2. **Probabilistic Results:** Scores and assessments are probabilistic and reflect the AI's best interpretation of available text and site structure. They are not infallible and may miss nuance, context, or recent changes not yet reflected online.
3. **Subjectivity of Classical Education:** "Classical Education" encompasses a range of traditions and interpretations (e.g., Dorothy Sayers' trivium model, Classical Christian Education, Great Books programs, etc.). The Humanitas Institute Audit of the Six Elements of Classical Education uses a broad, consensus-based framework derived from prominent classical education organizations and thought leaders. Reasonable people may disagree on weighting or inclusion of specific criteria.
4. **No Official Endorsement or Certification:** Results do not constitute official endorsement, accreditation, or certification by any classical education organization. They are provided for informational and research purposes only.
5. **Potential for Error:** Websites may be incomplete, poorly worded, or temporarily inaccurate. Conversely, sophisticated marketing language may create false positives. Human review by parents, educators, or classical education experts is strongly recommended before drawing final conclusions about any school.
6. **Data Privacy and Ethics:** Only publicly available information was analyzed. No attempts were made to access password-protected areas or collect personal data.
7. **No Liability:** The authors, developers, and distributors of this audit assume no liability for decisions made on the basis of these results. Users are solely responsible for their own due diligence.

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